



THIS IS **DAY 7 OF YOUR MENSTRUAL CYCLE**
273 days to go

WHAT'S HAPPENING INSIDE

Here an egg can be seen, in orange, developing in the ovary. The cells of the follicle, in which it is contained, can be seen surrounding the egg. At birth, baby girls have millions of follicles present in their ovaries.

“When you’re trying to get pregnant, you need to take your age into account because your fertility will decline as you get older.”

In about a week’s time, you are likely to ovulate. The ovaries are filled with follicles—fluid-filled structures in which the egg grows to maturity. Females are born with their lifetime supply of about 1 million eggs. They are not capable of making new eggs, and there is a continuous decline each month. By the time a girl enters puberty, only around 300,000 eggs remain. Of these, only 300–500 will ovulate over the 30–40 years of a woman’s reproductive life. It is possible to conceive from puberty until menopause. Menopausal women are advised to use contraception for two years after their last period.

Women in their early 20s are considered at their most fertile, and although, for most women, periods continue until their early 50s, the rate of fertility gradually lowers in the 30s, 40s, and 50s, and the rate of chromosomal abnormalities and miscarriage increases. Nonetheless, every year thousands of babies are born to women in their late 30s and 40s.

Fertility begins to fall off sharply after the age of 35. Your age also affects the quality of your eggs. In women in their early 20s, around 17 percent of eggs have a chromosomal abnormality, but the figure rises to over 75 percent in women in their 40s. Chromosomal problems increase the chances of having a child with a disorder such as [Down syndrome](#). It is possible to have a blood test that can give an indication of your remaining ovary reserve so that you know how much reproductive time you have left. While some traditional tests are based on levels of [FSH](#) and estrogen, others use markers found in the blood, such as anti-Mullerian hormone (AMH) and inhibin B. Alternatively, a vaginal ultrasound procedure, called an antral follicle count, can assess the number of small follicles seen in the ovaries. But conceiving is about more than ovulation; the egg has to be fertilized, implanted, and then the pregnancy maintained.